

to dig up the road next to Ilani's place. The month soon became two, then three and much to his chagrin, the promised connection was still missing in action six months after he had paid in cash. "Every time I called their franchisee, they would promise to get back to me in a few hours; would then invariably explain that the digging work is taking longer than expected and is expected to get over in a few weeks." So why did Ilani not ask for a refund and get out of the service when he should have? He explains, "Because, in the interim months, Powersurfer had increased the installation charges by about Rs 1,000. I thought that I had a good deal and I did not wish to give it up. After all, they promised a Net connection over optic fibres, it was too tempting an offer to pass up."

As Ilani would soon find out, it was the last-mile connect that was to be the undoing of his desire to get a fast connection to the Net. "After a period that must have been close to six months, I learned that I would have to settle for a refund since my residence was situated too far away for them to supply the last-mile connects. They had connected a cyber-cafe some 300 metres from my place, a distance that was apparently 'impractical' for them to cover with the requisite cabling," he fumes.

While Ilani's case reads like a typical botch-up job, those who did get connected to the Net via Powersurfer experience various levels of customer satisfaction: there are those who are content with what BTL offers, while others are terribly disappointed by the browsing speed, considering the fact that an optic fibre should

“ Lots of promises and assurances but all potholed in unexpected difficulties and problems—most of them concerning lack of transparency, miscommunication and above all, no sense of responsibility ”

—Raja Sagar, a Powersurfer customer

deliver a blazing experience. "It's the worst connection you could ever have," attests Vince Fern, a broadband user over an online forum. "I tested it for speed on a regular day, in the evening and found it to be just 16 Kbps. I can't even listen to a 28 Kbps online radio." Fern then goes on to attack their customer service: "Their helpline number has a peon who only speaks in Marathi and I am supposed to interact with him about speed and non-responsive pings! At the end of each complaint all this peon is programmed to say is 'mala kai mahiti nahi' (I don't know anything)."

Technology shmecnology

The idea of delivering the Internet over the same lines that bring you TV channels is an appealing one. The concept goes something like this: the wire that brings you cable TV has lots of unused room left on it. This unused bandwidth is used to deliver packets of data, the source of which can be anything—in the case of a broadband connect, the font being the Internet. The service provider will either have a private gateway to the Internet or will lease a line from another ISP such as VSNL. This Internet connection is then brought to a modem that combines the data from the Internet and the TV channel information onto a single cable, to be transmitted to subscribers. This flow of information from the service provider to an end-user is called the downstream data.

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